PROactive PRONUNCIATION

STRESS: Content vs. Function Words

In English, we stress or “linger” on the content words that hold meaning.
We de-stress or speed through the function words or the words that carry less meaning.

Content words

Content words are pretty much all the words that are not function words. For example,

- Nouns (e.g., paper, computer, Peter)
- (Most) main verbs (e.g., play, type)
- Adjectives (e.g., pretty, bright)
- Adverbs (e.g., often, quickly)
- Negatives including "nothing," "nowhere," etc.
- Words expressing quantities (e.g., a lot of, a couple, many, etc.)

Function words

Are typically little words that make the sentence grammatically make sense.
Example: the, a, an, it, she, he, of, in, on, about, around, this, there, have, had. These include:

- Prepositions (in, on, before, after)
- Pronouns (he, she, they, we, us, them, I)
- Determiners (the, a, some, an, a few)
- Verbs (have, be)
- Conjunctions (but, while, as, and)
- Auxiliary verbs (am, can, were)

Practice

Notice the content stressed words are bold and held longer, while the de-stressed function words are small and sped through:

State *of the* **art**
On *the* **go**
By *the* **way**
One *and the* **same**
Out *of the* **bag**
All *the* **way**

On *the* **fence**
Shoot *the* **breeze**
Over *the* **coun**ter
Clear *the* **air**
Out *of the* **blue**
Sur**vi**val *of the* **fit**test
Under *the* **wea**ther
I **look for**ward *to it*
Get *to the* **point**
I **go there** *from* **time** *to* **time**
I've **come** *to* **terms** *with it*
We **see eye** *to* **eye**
Get *me* **up** *to* **speed**
He's a **pain** *in the* **neck**
I'm **on** *the* **fence**
I'll **keep** *an* **eye** *on it*
He's **on** *a* **roll**
As a **mat**ter *of* **fact**
I'll **give** *it a* **whirl**
Once *in a* **blue moon**
Take *a* **look** *at it*
John met Sarah
Go *to* **work!**
How *are* **you?**
How *did you* **get there?**
The **boss** *is in the* **office**
She **beat** me
I'm **eat**ing *my* **break**fast
I **walked** *to the* **beach**
Don't forget *your* **water bottle**
I'm **almost done** *with my* **work** *for the* **day**
I **wish** *I* **had**n't for**gott**en *my* **bag**
I **love go**ing for *a* **walk** *on a* **bright sun**ny **day** *in the* **ci**ty.
I've been **lear**ning **En**glish *for a* **year**.
I have **so much** *to* **do** *this* **week**end**.**
Peter *and* **Sa**rah *will* **spend** *the* **week**end *at the* **co**ttage *with their* **friends.**
I would **not** *have* **ea**ten *if I had* **known Di**nner *was* **al**most **rea**dy**.**